
Interview

Geomancing is googling: Modern Earth divination and the spirits and ethics of tech

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Abstract Following an introduction to the specifically Afro-Islamic science of *geomancy*, this interview pairs a professional geomancer and Europeanist with an amateur geomancer and Islamicist to explore the ways in which this science—the OG Artificial Intelligence and parent of modern computing—continues to be not just a wonderfully useful and sustainable technology in its own right, but indispensable for thinking about the ethics of technology during our ecocidal and epistemicidal moment. It consists of modified excerpts from an online interview with Dr. Cummins conducted by Dr. Melvin-Koushki on January 10, 2025.

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The Afro-Islamic art of geomancy (*'ilm al-raml*, lit. 'sand science') was an occult science third in popularity only to astrology and oneiromancy throughout the early modern Western (Hellenic-Judeo-Christo-Islamic) world, with many derivations across sub-Saharan Africa and thence the western hemisphere; it remains globally popular today. Indeed, due to its early incorporation of astrological correspondences, it was often considered a form of 'terrestrial astrology' requiring much less astronomical and mathematical expertise while remaining richly informative. As a divinatory science based on a binary, *yin-yang* code, it is an Arabic cognate to the *I Ching*, but won much more popularity, over a far vaster area, than the ancient Chinese oracle. Early modern Persianate imperial elites in particular were greatly enamored of this computational technology specifically for its political, military, and scientific applications. Court geomancers forecast the outcome of campaigns, battles, and sieges, as well as the economic and climatic ups and downs of the coming year, among other services to the state. Beyond the court, physicians sometimes used it to help diagnose illnesses, and judges to help decide court cases. Geomancy was just as attractive to the common man and woman in the street, many of whom clearly relied on the advice of its professional practitioners to help them navigate the hopes and fears of daily life.

Technically, geomancy's binary code captures the flux patterns of the four elemental energies (fire, air, water, earth) as a means to divine past, present, and future events, and indeed the status of every thing or being in the sublunar realm, whence its common designation as 'celestial alchemy' too. Each of the sixteen geomantic figures acquired a full suite of specific elemental, astrological, calendrical, numerical, letterist-kabbalist, humoral, physiognomical, and other correspondences. The first twelve houses of the geomantic chart were likewise mapped onto the twelve planetary houses, and occasionally constructed in the form of a horoscope; astrological aspects (trine, sextile, square, opposition) were adopted as well. Detailed information can thus be derived from the figures and their relationships about virtually any aspect of human experience, whether physical, mental or spiritual, whether past, present, or future, revealing with precision such categories of data as the following: numbers, letters, days, months, years, astral bodies and divisions, body parts, physical and facial characteristics, minerals, precious stones, plants and plant products, animals and animal products, birds, fruits, tastes, colors, places, directions, regions, topographies, genders, social classes, nations, weapons, diseases, etc. As its bestselling manuals of the vast early modern Persianate world make clear, geomancy was used by two-thirds of the human race as an occult, early modern form of googling—as well as social networking, wiretapping, trade forecasting, weather forecasting, job finding, matchmaking, CT scanning, ultrasounding, metal detecting, lie detecting, home surveilling, and radar.



As with many Arabic sciences, especially of the occult variety, geomancy likewise boomed in popularity among the humanists of the European Renaissance as an obvious technological application of the *prisca sapientia* (wisdom of the ancients). But here too the Arabic-to-Latin transmission was very partial, and early modern Latinate geomancy remained largely pinned to those texts that happened to be done into Latin, inexpertly, during the translation movement of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries; Western Christian scholars (though not Eastern ones) remained totally ignorant of contemporary Persianate and African advances. Given such a piecemeal reception, various technical applications and procedures of Arabic geomancy became so garbled in Latin as to be unusable, and most of those that became standard in the Islamic world remained unknown to the Latin Christian. Despite this Islamo-Christian divergence, however, its epistemic allure was such that it still held sway over some of the greatest minds of the ‘Scientific Revolution’: when Francis Bacon valorized artificial divination over natural as an essential component of his scientific method, he was referring to geomancy—the same technology that inspired Leibniz to invent modern computing.

Matthew Melvin-Koushki: How does a modern geomancer come to be?

Alexander Cummins: How indeed, good grief. Geomancy was for me an ideal intersection of my academic interest in the social history of applied magic in the early modern British Isles and my personal commitment to putting theory into practice, as well as embodiment in general. I grew up in Birmingham, which was very multicultural in the eighties, and practiced martial arts (particularly aikido) with my dad and sister from a very young age. So when I became drawn to the study of seventeenth-century England and the question of how revolutionary ideals and praxes come together, it was through the lenses of occultism, magic, mythology, and world religion—and personal experimentation.

In tandem with my formal academic training in Western occult philosophy, through practice I came to understand divination as *a way of knowing what do to when we don't know what to do*. I first went through a tarot phase, reading for myself and friends, and increasingly for strangers too, through invitations to do events; I did the festival circuit for years, doing both divination and performance poetry, and was hired as a site wizard for music festivals and similar things. In this capacity I was looking after people who'd taken too many hallucinogens and mediating between the fields and forests where UK festivals often happen, between local spirits (*genii loci*) and those of the events themselves. Here I found geomancy to be exceptionally useful for giving practical feedback to all comers, and not simply in a predictive mode, but also for framing what's going on right now

and understanding the inertias cohering around a moment, how to harness its momentum to move forward in a way that's productive.

From my years of moving between these various public and academic communities and studying historical geomancers, I can testify that implementing their techniques is a reliably excellent postmedieval, pre-modern means of solving for modern and even some postmodern problems. And however badly the historiography of Western occultism has treated geomancy in the past, there's no need to don sackcloth and ash, it's not all lost: the old and new handbooks have the same nuance and complexity as ever they did and answer the same fundamental human concerns.

Melvin-Koushki: Amen, and same here! So as an Islamicist but mere amateur practitioner of this, my favorite Afro-Islamic divinatory science and daily driver, I'm curious as to your professional sense of the *personality* of geomancy—at least through its postmedieval Latinate reception—compared to other divinatory modes?

Cummins: Yes, I'm personally more rooted in the European Renaissance geomantic tradition, though am grateful to have colleagues and friends trained in its various Islamic and other forms. Geomancy as such is obviously firmly within the Western occultosphere of the four elements and so on, which is why my colleague Sam Block calls it 'theoretical alchemy.'¹ But in terms of its actual character on the ground (pun intended), I often talk about geomancy in terms of both technology and performance, and technologies of performance. I liken it to the *bass guitar*.

The bass guitar is an instrument you can sound okay on pretty quickly, can pick up and play the root notes of things and accompany other musicians. But to master all of its syncopations and root-note chord changes takes a lifetime. Think the (usually) four strings as the four lines of a geomantic figure. Each of the sixteen geomantic figures (4×4)—ruled or fueled by the seven classical planets in two modes each, plus the north and south nodes of the Moon—are a little diagram of how astro-elemental virtues are playing or not playing with each other at any given moment. So despite its theoretical basis in astrology as well as alchemy, geomancy is not concerned with time and zeitgeist, but rather with strictly practical matters and strategies *now*.

Geomancy can of course be predictive; but I find it especially effective in helping people work out what's going on in their lives, giving them the wheel to navigate the patterns that are playing out and avoid getting hit by the car of them. All good divination is about increasing *agency* and *responsibility* and *sovereignty*: to know more so you can do more now.

Melvin-Koushki: Right, like all good technology, immediately accessible and empowering but potentially endlessly complex, as I've found from

1 See his extensive geomantic content at <https://digitalambler.com/about/geomancy-posts>, and forthcoming manual.



both doing and teaching it myself. The early modern Persianate forms I work on are especially sophisticated, and most of their techniques are still beyond me. That they're specifically imperial, in sharp contrast to provincial Latinate receptions, makes them both much more comprehensive and much more focused on political, military, and economic prognostication, and hence closely allied with astrology; until recently the court astrologer and the court geomancer were often the same person.

So the science's Persianate and Latinate personalities (to say nothing of its many African ones) would seem to diverge quite a bit on that and other fronts. Especially textually: in extreme contrast to the mere 150 or so Latinate manuscript witnesses extant, manuscripts copies of Arabic, Persian, and various Islamic vernacular geomantic texts survive in their *tens of thousands*, to say nothing of lithograph and modern printings, and that in the face of the depredations of European and Soviet colonialism and dogged academic Eurocentrism.² Its many decolonial advances aside, the academy is still very much addicted to the revenge fantasy of Islam as the Not-West, still reflexively treats Platonic-Pythagorean Islamic occultism as the superstition of the uncivilizable natives—which is why I, bizarrely, seem to be the only professional historian in the world working on these amazingly technically and philosophically innovative early modern Persian geomantic manuals.

But I love the musical instrument analogy—for my Persianate philosophers geomancy is explicitly a Pythagorean science after all! Personally, I've successfully played the saxophone but tried and failed to play the bagpipes, despite my Scots-Irish blood.

Cummins: The same rule applies, absolutely! I've heard saxophones are another one of those instruments that can be picked up and not sound terrible straight away. I've also heard bagpipes are maybe the opposite of that, and also the violin, which sounds pretty bad for quite a while. So yes, geomancy as the bass guitar and saxophone of divinatory systems, where the bar to entry is low but the mysteries are still profound. That's a feature, not a bug, as far as I'm concerned.

Tarot has a very different personality, though only in my experience. I know incredibly gifted tarot readers who can achieve the same precision, specificity, and nuance as geomancy normally gives. My own interactions with tarot have been a lot more like talking to a batty aunt (all of whom I love!). But it's very good for writers, and for exploring ideas that don't have easy answers.

Melvin-Koushki: Fascinating, yes—I can't get tarot to work at all, but for me geomancy is like falling off an algorithmic log. I experience

2 There is likewise a weird tendency in Latinate geomancy to drop the sixteenth and last cell of the chart, breaking the standard Arabo-Persian 4×4 pattern, with a possible 65,536 combinations. On the obscenely imbalanced comparative Christian-Jewish *vs.* Islamic and African state of the field, see Melvin-Koushki (2023).

geomancing as googling. The weird thing is, a great host of postmedieval users clearly did as well. As a Gen-X, internet-adoring historian of Pythagoreanism and science, I'm of course a little biased; yet my early modern sources not only insist on classifying it as a Pythagorean mathematical science, Matrix-style, but pump its algorithm for much the same actionable intel on perennial themes as we do search engines today: sex, taxes, and death. (Though a question more popular then than now is 'When and how will I die and what will happen after?') After all, it's no accident that, thanks to Leibniz, geomancy became an impetus for modern computing.

Cummins: The human heart has not necessarily changed that much. And I really like the split I first encountered in Jim Baker's book (2014) on early modern cunning craft, which classifies divinatory systems along a computational/non-computational axis. This is far from a hard and fast division, needless to say; depending on the practitioner, non-computational methodologies like dream interpretation, augury or spirit communication can be essential for making a computational reading actionable, and I certainly use these as appropriate. But in strictly computational systems like geomancy (also playing cards or dice), *the answer is the answer*.

At the same time, one of my teachers says a good diviner should be able to use whatever they happen to have on hand to get an actionable answer. Such methods usually get dismissed as 'folk divination,' from tea-leaf reading to egg reading to throwing an apple peel behind your shoulder—but I have a lot of time for these too. The point of all divination is to quickly and efficiently put the querent behind the wheel, to mitigate factors that can be mitigated or understand how to weather those that must be weathered, especially when combined with more active spellcraft, talismanry, and spirit work. But the aim is always to better move through difficulties and claim agency and enjoy life wherever possible. And would you rather put in a ton of time and effort to make a very small change, or do something very simple that can have far-reaching consequences?

One of the reasons for geomancy's current obscurity is the Scientific Revolution trend toward making low-bar, accessible occult technologies more complicated and arcane, part of a grand mystic quest, rather than a practical way of simply living in the sublunary world. The same applies to astrology, with the seventeenth-century print explosion of almanacs: suddenly the elite-approved technologies of truthmaking become more exclusively lab-based, requiring expensive equipment and colleges of approving and (more usually) disapproving peers. Geomancy too was subject to this gatekeeping process, whereby easy computing came to be dismissed as inaccurate, as non-science, for the same classist reasons. So in



the Anglosphere today, more occultists have only heard of geomancy than actually seen it practiced, since it invites fewer labyrinthine digressions on the grand state of the cosmos, despite being rooted in the maths of the universe.

Melvin-Koushki: Given its importance to the history of computing, I often pitch geomancy as the OG Artificial Intelligence: my early modern Persianate imperial geomancers occupied the same sociopolitical niche that Silicon Valley tech bros do today. Yet they quested not for AGI but ACI, Artificial Cosmic Intelligence, and experimented with rewriting the world in a binary code to that more sustainable and (usually) less apocalyptic end.

The so-called Scientific Revolution aside (a twentieth-century academic construct), what's your sense of the Latinate geomancers you work with? How might their spirits and ethics inform our own use of computing tech?

Cummins: My dead geomancers are an idiosyncratic bunch, and wild experimenters! Many have completely different correspondences between the sixteen figures and the twelve zodiacal signs, for instance—that's what works for them. Their suites of techniques therefore vary quite a lot from person to person and century to century. Yet they combine this experimentalism with a salutary traditionalism to ensure *information hygiene*. Ancestor reverence guides geomantic ethics. And personally, as a folk necromancer, I often interact with dead geomancers as tutelary spirits. Some lineages even take the science back to Adam in the Garden as its inventor. This is very exciting for me in terms of how it connects up with the first ancestor—the first human as the first magician—and so the primordial *humanness* of divination, amongst many, many other themes.

So yes: by demanding interrelation with the living and the dead, with the cosmos as community, geomancy demands in turn a greatly expanded ethics, whether serving spirits or clients.

As for the search-engine model, whose crawlers and spiders go forth to gather and filter raw data into information: they behave quite like geomantic spirits and effective virtues—hence the importance for me of the opening invocatory prayer for measuring current conditions.

Melvin-Koushki: Latin Adam himself, very cool. In the Persianate context, Daniel, Enoch (Idrīs), and Pythagoras are typically the favorite ancestor-inventors, given the greater emphasis on geomancy as a mathematical prognosticative technology marrying heaven to earth to rule all.

And information hygiene, amen—a basic requirement that is algorithmically almost impossible today. What can geomancy teach us

informationally unhygienic postmoderns, ensorcelled by our panopticonic Black Mirrors, about healthier uses of the Algorithm, which seeks to monetize our subconscious 24/7?

Cummins: Tools not properly attended are liable to get squatted. Divination brings this postmodern problem front and center: actionable readings require *active participation* and *informed consent*. Hence the need for protocols and containers; I have an elder who's very big on the idea of building the container that will be helpful for you, while also participating in the community of the living and the dead. The mysteries that traditions safeguard are *renewable resources*. I also have a conjure doctor friend, Professor Charles Porterfield, who holds to that truism of folk magic: if it works for you, it can work for me too. This both discourages solipsism—often our problems are more common than personal—and encourages conceptual and verbal discipline in crafting questions.

Melvin-Koushki: Exactly, the golden rule that is GIGO: junk questions only get you junk answers or worse. But current AI is trained on random grabs of mostly the Anglophone internet, already terminally junkified, then hallucinates further to hamfistedly colonialist ends. (The gods help you if you're an Islamicist historian of occult science!) By contrast, the geomantic algorithm has been rigorously tested over the last millennium by a huge swath of the human race across many cultures and languages and geographies. This quality control seems to have protected against noise (bot infestation) and general derangement; even as an amateur, my readings are consistently over 90% on target, and some of my undergraduate students experience an excellent hit rate with very little training. So not only is it free and entirely open-source, but requires only the most rudimentary grasp of Platonic-Pythagorean metaphysics and Aristotelian physics to get reliable, quality-controlled results out of the box. It sounds like that's your experience personally and with clients too?

Cummins: Indeed! My job is often more electrician than physicist (or metaphysicist): once the basic principles are mastered, few technologies are more practical or portable or adaptable, or more encouraging of new experimentation by all its users, yes, regardless of culture and time and place. Practice must precede theory, so we don't overthink to the point of choice paralysis. All instruments have their limits. The geomantic figures are shelfmarks of reality, haunted doorways, archives of befalling fate—with the advantage that following their patterns is more experimentally likely to be creative rather than destructive.



Melvin-Koushki: Its Latinate receptions certainly rewired and jerryrigged their handful of early medieval Arabic sources in locally adapted new ways—whence the boom in geomancy’s popularity in the Anglosphere today, with your own career as Exhibit A!

As a treehugging historian of science and empire, I take every opportunity to bash AI as environment-destroying and information-corrupting computing tech run imperially amok. The answer cannot be trusted to be the answer. Yet one of the great ironies of our postmodern moment is that the enshittification of the Earth and all human knowledge has its genetic roots in this Earth science, ruled as it is by Hermes, god/goddess of tech and ultimate Trickster. Under these weirding and Tricky circumstances, it must be fun to be a site wizard mediating between forests and all-consuming, too-hallucinogenic data farms. What’s your sense of geomancy’s future as the most sustainable, accessible, adaptable, open-source, and literally *ecofriendly* computing technology ever coded in Western cultures to date?

Cummins: I’m pretty sanguine on the future of geomancy. Without getting too rose-tinted or starry-eyed, and despite the devils we dance with on social media, the internet has made it possible for many different world geomancies to talk and evolve and become more resilient together.

And yes, unlike postmodern technologies, it has a grand *anti-fragility*; I agree that our current algorithmic reality is probably the most fragile system ever created. Traditional yet experimental, free yet informationally hygienic, postmedieval geomantic computing may well outlast its post-modern competitors as a foundational epistemology, an anti-fragile way of thinking better about our thinking and acting better about our acting. Past, present, and future remain undiscovered country—and we are always in training to become good future ancestors.

About the authors

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Alexander Cummins (PhD Bristol) is a contemporary cunning-man and historian of magic. His magical specialities are the dead (folk necromancy), divination (geomancy), and the grimoires. His published works include *Nazarth: Pillars of Gladness* (2022), *An Excellent Booke of the Arte of Magicke* (2020, with Phil Legard), *The Starry Rubric* (2012), *A Book of the Magi: Lore, Prayers, and Spellcraft of the Three Holy Kings* (2018), and several chapbooks, as well as essays in collections by Three Hands Press, Hadean Press, and academic presses such as Palgrave Macmillan. He is a frequent speaker on the international circuit, co-hosts the podcast Radio Free Golgotha, and is a founding editor of the Folk Necromancy in Transmission series at Revelore Press. Dr. Cummins' work, classes, and services can be found at alexandercummins.com. E-mail: consultantsorcerer@gmail.com

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